and sixty years of independent development behind them, China and India seek great power status. In the 1950s, however, they sought something apparently less ambitious but which, in the context of their recent colonial history, was as important, namely a respect in the eyes of the world comparable with their size, the antiquity of their civilization, and the distinctiveness of their national revolution.

Towards the end of 1959, after the first clashes on the border, and the arrival into India of the Dalai Lama, Jawaharlal Nehru was interviewed by the American journalist Edgar Snow. In Snow's recollection, Nehru told him that 'the basic reason for the Sino-Indian dispute was that they were both "new nations", in that both were newly independent and under dynamic nationalistic leaderships, and in a sense were meeting at their "frontiers" for the first time in history; hence it was natural that a certain degree of conflict should be generated before they could stabilize their frontiers.' Nehru added that in the past there were 'buffer zones' between the two countries/civilizations, but now India and China were 'filling out, and meeting [for the first time] as modern nations on the borders'.

Nehru was speaking here not as a politician—whether pragmatic or idealist—but as a student of history. In this, more detached, role, he could see that a clash of arms, and of ideologies and aspirations behind it, was written into the logic of the respective and collective histories of India and China.

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In 1961, when relations between the two countries had more or less broken down, India withdrew its ambassador to Beijing. China did likewise. For the next fifteen years, the two countries ran skeletal offices in each other's capital. Finally, in 1976, full diplomatic relations were resumed. In the same year Mao Zedong died.

Deng Xiaoping, who emerged as the most important leader in China soon after Mao's death, wished to overcome the baggage of 1962, and set